PRFERENCE NATIONALE

-FATOU DIOME

1.Read the following passage and write the answers to the questions given below

The law changed very quietly, thanks to Mr Borders: if you're married to a French citizen, it will now take two years for you to claim the benefits of citizenship. By this delay, Mr Borders is relying on the nature of his countrymen to break up the relationship. Then, as the ex-wife of a Frenchman, the foreign woman becomes no more than an ex-object. And as with any object, she has no rights, not even the right to earn an honest living. They won't give me citizenship, but my Senegalese cat has his papers. Perhaps it's because he's ginger.

QUESTIONS

Q1: What change has been made to the law regarding French citizenship, and who is behind it?
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Q2: What is the likely intention behind this law change?

Q3: What is the consequence for a foreign woman if her relationship with a French citizen ends?

Q4: What point is the author making with the mention of the Senegalese cat?

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Q5:Find a word from the passage meaning ‘nationality’.

ANSWERS

A1: The law now requires a 2-year wait for spouses of French citizens to claim citizenship benefits, thanks to Mr. Borders.

A2: Mr. Borders is likely relying on the nature of relationships to break up, making it harder for foreign women to claim rights

.A3: She loses her rights, including the right to earn a living, becoming like an "ex-object" with no rights

.A4: The author is highlighting the absurdity of the situation, implying it's easier for a cat to get papers than a person.

Q5;Citizenship.

2.Read the following passage and write the answers of the following questions.

2. Madame is French, true, but hasn't even passed her first degree and seems to think she could not tutor her daughter herself. She is refusing me work on account of my black lips which can drone the niceties of French grammar better than hers.
Pouring mocktail on top of my rage, I stand up and face her with this parting shot: "Goodbye, madame. If you saw what I have between my ears, you wouldn't be working as a supermarket cashier."

QUESTIONS

Q1: What is the narrator's opinion of Madame's decision to refuse them work?

Q2: Why does the narrator think Madame is unqualified to tutor her daughter?

Q3: How does the narrator respond to Madame's refusal?

Q4: What does the narrator imply about their own abilities?

Q5;Find a word from the passage meaning ‘a non alcoholic drink’.

ANSWERS

A1: The narrator believes Madame is refusing them work due to prejudice,being black.

A2: Madame hasn't passed her first degree, implying she's not academically qualified for tutoring.

A3: The narrator confronts Madame, making a witty and slightly insulting remark about Madame's job as a supermarket cashier.

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A4: The narrator implies they are highly knowledgeable about French grammar, more so than Madame.

Q5; Mocktail.

DISCOURSES

1.Prepare a write up on the short story PREFERENCE NATIONALE by FATOU DIOME

Préférence Nationale by Fatou Diome is a short story collection exposing immigrant struggles in France, focusing on racism, discrimination, and identity particularly through a Senegalese narrator facing systemic barriers to citizenship and employment despite qualifications, highlighting hypocrisy where even a pet gets papers but she's rejected for her black skin in job searches.

The narrative uses biting satire, like the narrator's cat having papers while she waits for citizenship due to a discriminatory law, and direct encounters with prejudice, such as bakery owners preferring local accents or employers wanting "European-type" people, all while asserting her inherent dignity.

The narrator, a highly educated Senegalese woman, grapples with feeling like an outsider in France, her French education devalued by her race.

The story vividly depicts overt and subtle racism in France, from official citizenship hurdles to casual job rejections.

Diome uses sharp humor, as the narrator's cat receiving official papers before she does, to critique French immigration policies and societal attitudes.

- “National Preference”: The title refers to the idea of prioritizing native French citizens, a concept the story shows being enacted by individuals through discriminatory hiring and social practices, despite the narrator's legal claims.

She's denied a job at a bakery for not speaking the local dialect (Alsatian) and rejected for tutoring because she's Black, reinforcing her feelings of humiliation and invisibility.

2.Prepare a REVIEW of the short story PREFERENCE NATIONALE by Fatou DIOME.

Préférence Nationale" by Fatou Diome is a biting critique of immigration and racial discrimination in France, told through the experiences of a Senegalese narrator who faces systemic barriers despite her education. The story mixes sharp satire—like the ironic scene where her cat gets official papers before she does—with poignant moments of identity struggle and exclusion, highlighting how "national preference" fuels everyday prejudice in hiring and social interactions, leaving the protagonist feeling invisible and humiliated. The narrative effectively exposes the gap between legal rights and lived racism in contemporary French society.

There is a quest for Identity and Belonging,the narrator's struggle highlights the complexities of being an immigrant in France, caught between cultures and facing rejection despite fluency in French and education.

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Satirically Diome uses humor to critique societal norms, like the absurdity of a cat getting papers while the narrator faces endless hurdles.

Racism is one major factor in the story which showcases how "national preference" translates into everyday discrimination, from job rejections to citizenship obstacles, emphasizing institutional biases.

3.Prepare a DIARY ENTRY made by Fatou on the day she was rejected from the job at the bakery.

MONDAY, 7th

Oh .....My heart is shattered tonight. I went to the big bakery, ready to take any job, ready to sell bread and pastries just to eat. But it wasn't even about the job in the end. It was about my skin.....my skin..... The boss, with his German moustache and French flag hat, barely even looked at my qualifications. He didn't want a salesgirl; he wanted someone who could speak his regional dialect. And then, the ultimate insult—he asked me why I don't just "go and work in your own country."The sheer arrogance of it! After everything their country has taken from mine—our sugar, our peanuts, even our people for their wars. I felt such rage, but I just walked away. All my education, my French degree, means nothing because of my color. I'm just an ex-object. My spirits have sunk to the bottom. I hate feeling this humiliated and unwanted.

4.Draft a letter of complaint that Fatou had written to the officials regarding her views on implementing the law of preference nationale

From
FATOU DIOME
Flat No.45
Queens plaza
Paris

To: The Officer
FOREIGN SERVICES
PARIS

Subject: Formal Complaint regarding discriminatory application of National Preference policies.

To the Honorable Officials,

I am writing to formally express my deep concern and professional grievance regarding the recent implementation of "Preference Nationale" within the country.
While I understand the legislative framework intended to prioritize citizens, I have observed—and personally experienced—that this policy is being used as a tool for systemic exclusion rather than a balanced economic measure. Specifically, I wish to highlight that ,
Qualified individuals are being overlooked for roles they are legally entitled to hold, solely based on origin, despite meeting all professional criteria.I myself am a victim of this.
A society's strength is measured not by how it excludes, but by how it integrates the talents of all those who call it home.
I am requesting a formal review of the current selection processes .

DDE KOLLAM

I look forward to your prompt response and a transparent explanation of the steps being taken to ensure equity and justice for all residents.

Sincerely
Fatou Diome

Read the following lines from the poem MIRROR and answer the questions given below

I am silver and exact. I have no preconceptions.
Whatever I see I swallow immediately
Just as it is, unmisted by love or dislike.
I am not cruel, only truthful,
The eye of a little god, four-cornered.
Most of the time I meditate on the opposite wall.
It is pink, with speckles. I have looked at it so long
I think it is part of my heart. But it flickers.
Faces and darkness separate us over and over.

QUESTIONS.

1.How does the mirror describe itself in the first line?

2. What does the phrase "I have no preconceptions" imply about the mirror?

3. Explain the metaphor: "The eye of a little god, four-cornered."

4. What does the mirror do "most of the time"?

5. What are the two things that "separate" the mirror from the wall?

ANSWERS

Answer 1: The mirror describes itself as "silver and exact." This suggests it is clear, precise, and provides an honest reflection without any distortion.

Answer 2: It implies that the mirror is completely unbiased. It does not judge what it sees based on beauty, age, or personal feelings; it simply reflects the truth as it is.

Answer 3; The mirror views itself as a "little god" because it is all-seeing and objective within its rectangular body

Answer 4: Most of the time, the mirror "meditates on the opposite wall." It stares at a pink, speckled wall .

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Answer 5: The mirror is separated from the wall by "faces and darkness.

2**.Read the following lines from the poem MIRROR and answer the questions given below**

Now I am a lake. A woman bends over me,
Searching my reaches for what she really is.
Then she turns to those liars, the candles or the moon.

I see her back, and reflect it faithfully.
She rewards me with tears and an agitation of hands.
I am important to her. She comes and goes.

Each morning it is her face that replaces the darkness.
In me she has drowned a young girl, and in me an old woman
Rises toward her day after day, like a terrible fish.

QUESTIONS

1.What does the speaker think is part of their heart

2.What does the woman search for in the lake?"

3.What does the woman turn to after searching the lake?

4.How does the speaker describe their reflection of the women?

5.Find an example of a simile from the above lines.

ANSWERS

ANS1.The opposite wall,

ANS 2.What she really is.

ANS.3 The candles or the moon

ANS 4.Faithful

ANS 5. The lines ‘in an old woman
Rises toward her day after day, like a terrible fish’.

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